

OPINION

The American flag should be a unifying symbol that transcends politics

For more than 200 years, the flag has played an important role in our nation's history.



Object preview

Phil Halpern

A painting the author produced while he was a college student.



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PUBLISHED: July 2, 2021 at 6:14 PM PDT | UPDATED: August 11, 2021 at 7:37 PM PDT

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***Halpern** was an assistant U.S. attorney for 36 years in the U.S. Attorney's Office in San Diego. He lives in Mission Hills.*

It has long been my belief that the American flag should be a unifying symbol that transcends politics. As a child, I was taught how to hang, fold, store and salute the American flag. As a college student, I painted the flag for a class and displayed it proudly in my dorm room. As a career prosecutor, the American flag adorned each office and courtroom in which I practiced.

My lifelong connection to the flag is not surprising. For more than 200 years, the flag has played an important role in our nation's history. It represents our fierce independence, our commitment to liberty and justice, and our essential belief in the dignity of each and every citizen. Indeed, for many, it symbolizes the very essence of being an American.

On the other hand, throughout our nation's history — and especially in times of crisis — the flag has been utilized for political purposes. For much of the 1960s and 1970s, the flag was used as a countercultural symbol by people on the "left" opposed to racism, the war in Vietnam and the existing power structure. Civil rights activists marched with the flag in an effort to pressure politicians to live up to the ideals of freedom and equality. Vietnam protesters burned the flag, stitched it into the back of jean jackets, and stenciled it onto motorcycle helmets as a symbol of their opposition to the war.

As a direct response to these anti-war protesters, congressional candidates began wearing American flag pins. In 1972, Richard Nixon became the [first president](#) to follow suit. Due to the numerous scandals surrounding his presidency, however, flag pins practically disappeared from the lapels of American presidents for almost 30 years.

More recently, many people on the "right" have attempted to co-opt the flag for partisan political purposes. Indeed, the flag was displayed by many rioters (along with many far-right and White supremacist symbols) who laid siege to the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6. Sadly, on that day a pole bearing an American flag was used to break down doors and assault police officers protecting the Capitol.

Those rioters — and the politicians who enabled them — were not expressing any form of patriotism, only their misguided beliefs and political leanings. A politician from either party who hugs the American flag purely to secure votes, or wears a flag pin solely to appeal to constituents, is simply playing politics — not displaying patriotism.

If our country is to continue as a democracy, no party can have a monopoly on displaying the flag or on loving our country. All Americans, and all who hope to be Americans, must be able to draw inspiration equally from our flag. No one on the right or the left should be left out.

Our country was built by bringing people together, not by splitting them apart. On Independence Day, I will proudly fly the flag outside my house as an American who wants the best this country has to offer for all people, regardless of their political beliefs.

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